

Psalms 33

Praise the Creator

By the word of the Lord were the heavens made
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 Rejoice in the LORD, O ye righteous: for praise is comely for the upright.
- 2 Praise the LORD with harp: sing unto him with the psaltery and an instrument of ten strings.
- 3 Sing unto him a new song; play skilfully with a loud noise.
- 4 For the word of the LORD is right; and all his works are done in truth.
- 5 He loveth righteousness and judgment: the earth is full of the goodness of the LORD.
- 6 By the word of the LORD were the heavens made; and all the host of them by the breath of his mouth.
- 7 He gathereth the waters of the sea together as an heap: he layeth up the depth in storehouses.
- 8 Let all the earth fear the LORD: let all the inhabitants of the world stand in awe of him.
- 9 For he spake, and it was done; he commanded, and it stood fast.
- 10 The LORD bringeth the counsel of the heathen to nought: he maketh the devices of the people of none effect.
- 11 The counsel of the LORD standeth for ever, the thoughts of his heart to all generations.
- 12 Blessed is the nation whose God is the LORD: and the people whom he hath chosen for his own inheritance.
- 13 The LORD looketh from heaven; he beholdeth all the sons of men.
- 14 From the place of his habitation he looketh upon all the inhabitants of the earth.
- 15 He fashioneth their hearts alike; he considereth all their works.
- 16 There is no king saved by the multitude of an host: a mighty man is not delivered by much strength.
- 17 An horse is a vain thing for safety: neither shall he deliver any by his great strength.
- 18 Behold, the eye of the LORD is upon them that fear him, upon them that hope in his mercy;
- 19 To deliver their soul from death, and to keep them alive in famine.
- 20 Our soul waiteth for the LORD: he is our help and our shield.
- 21 For our heart shall rejoice in him, because we have trusted in his holy name.
- 22 Let thy mercy, O LORD, be upon us, according as we hope in thee.

2 · CONTEXT

Psalm 33 is a pure hymn of praise with no lament at all, fittingly following Psalm 32's closing call to "shout for joy." It moves from an invitation to sing with instruments, to the reliability of God's word seen in creation ("he spake, and it was done"), to His sovereign rule over the plans of nations, and finally to covenant assurance for those who fear Him and hope in His mercy. Henry treats it as corporate worship expanding personal testimony into praise of the Creator-King who governs both galaxies and governments.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

A call to rejoice and praise with harp and psaltery, to "sing unto him a new song" and play skillfully—worship as both heartfelt and prepared.

Verse 4-5

The word of the Lord is right; all His works are done in truth. He loves righteousness and judgment, and "the earth is full of the goodness of the Lord."

Verse 6-9

Creation itself came by His word and breath; He gathers the seas as in a bag and stores the deep. All the earth is called to fear Him, because He speaks and it stands fast—His decree is as reliable as His creation.

Verse 10-12

He brings the counsel of nations to nought, but His own counsel stands forever, through all generations. Blessed is the nation whose God is the Lord.

Verse 13-15

The Lord looks down from heaven on all the sons of men; He fashions every heart alike and considers all their works. Nothing about human plans escapes His notice.

Verse 16-19

No king is saved by the size of his army, no mighty man by great strength, no horse by its power. But the Lord’s eye is on those who fear Him and hope in His mercy, to deliver their soul from death and keep them alive in famine.

Verse 20-22

The soul waits for the Lord; He is help and shield. The heart rejoices in Him and trusts His holy name. The psalm closes as a prayer: let Thy mercy be upon us, according as we have hoped in Thee.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

God’s spoken word is the ground of both cosmic order and covenant hope: what He says, stands. Nations and armies cannot manufacture the security that comes only from being watched over by the God who made the seas and fashions every heart.

Application for life today.

Let creation itself—the reliability of sunrise, seasons, gravity—become a call to worship the God whose word never fails. When national or political anxiety rises, remember that “the counsel of the heathen” is real but never final; God’s counsel stands. Examine whether you are trusting horses, armies, or strategies (v. 17) more than the Lord’s steadfast mercy.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where in creation or current events do you see “the earth full of the goodness of the Lord” (v. 5), even amid disorder?

2. What “horse” or “army”—a strategy, a resource, a person—are you tempted to trust more than the Lord right now?

3. How does knowing God “fashioneth” every heart alike (v. 15) shape how you view people who oppose or frustrate you?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).